

THE SANTA BARBARA ISLANDS.

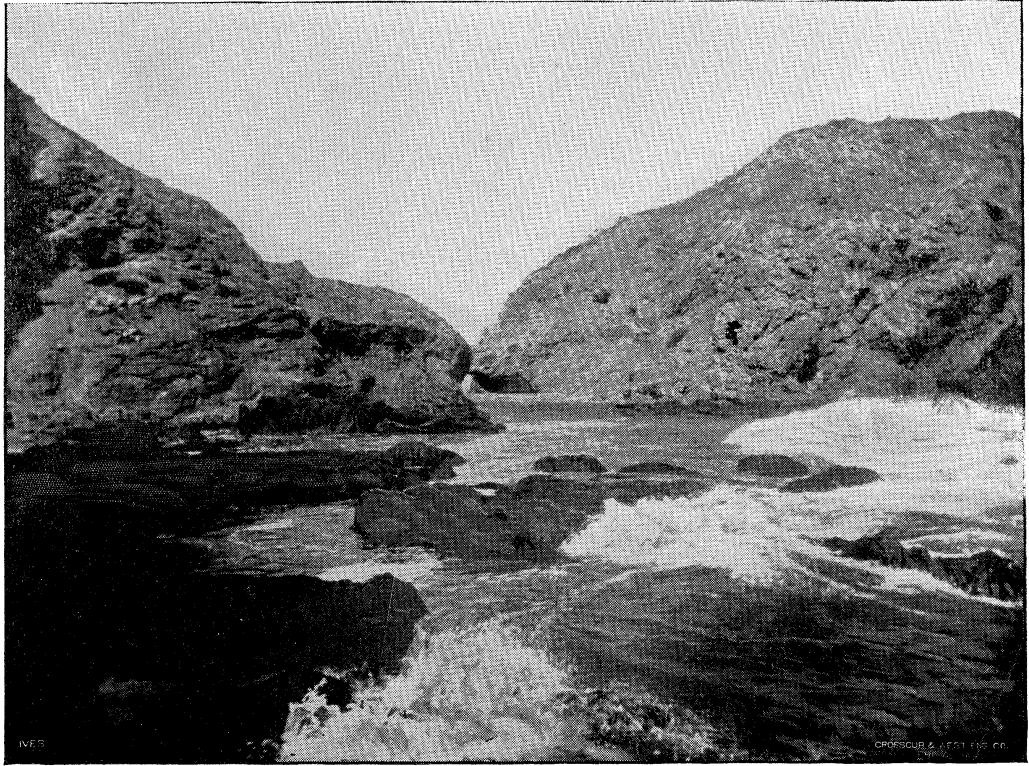


Photo by I. N. Cook.

THE PASSAGE BETWEEN THE ANACAPAS.

ROMANTIC, isolated, almost unknown to the world in general, the Santa Barbara Islands have thus far almost entirely eluded the tourist's eye. Strange, indeed, it is, that in these days of travel and still-hunting for novelty, this natural museum of wonders should keep out of the route-books. Geographies and encyclopedias hardly mention this group, which in many respects resembles that unique cluster, the Channel Islands, off the Normandy coast.

But this omission on the part of book-makers helps to reserve one fresh, unbeaten byway for the few not content with the ruts of travel. These gardens in the sea are more lonely and untrodden today than for centuries before the white man's coming,—for

before that event they were densely populated. Now they are little more than sheepwalks. Trespassing is very sternly forbidden by the various owners and lessees, and the aborigines that once must have enjoyed an ideal existence there have perished.

And few among the thousands who gaze admiringly over the leagues of shining water have even tried to visit these almost mysterious islands. To residents and strangers alike they are simply charming accessories to the mainland prospect. All the coast steamers and mail steamships pass in sight of the islands, but the only vessels that land there regularly are schooners that bring away our market supply of mutton. Italian fishermen

and Chinese junk crews know the waters well and depend on them for inexhaustible fishing.

If smugglers also do not there ply their trade, they miss the best vantage-ground on the Pacific, as the lonely coasts abound in deep caves and convenient landing-places for small boats.

Avoided as they are now, however, these neglected shores had the distinction of entertaining the first excursion party to California, 349 years ago. Very restful and serene must have looked the Santa Barbara Islands to their first visitors from afar, when, one October afternoon in 1542, that gallant sea rover, Cabrillo, and his crew of buccaneers sailed up the blue and silver channel. Outside a sou'wester was raging, and according to the ancient diary, still preserved, of the *Piloto Mayor*, or sailing master, the two unwieldy vessels, a galleon and convoy, were right fortunate to make any sort of harbor. Finding this tranquil waterway as unruffled by the roaring winds outside as one of their own Andalusian lakes, the spent sailors rejoiced and hastened to cast anchor in quiet moorings near one of the "Islands of Rest and Peace, where," says the chronicle,

"neither gales nor rude tides disturbed the shelter."

The Spaniards remained here long enough to make an inventory of their discovery. On either side of the thirty-mile wide channel rose mountain walls. The lofty Santa Ynez on the mainland was margined by a crescent of rich coast valleys. The two larger islands, mostly precipitous at shore line, ascended with many a broad upland curve and terrace to a mountain backbone. Heavy woods of pine, oak, and ironwood, interspersed with meadows of brown grass, swept from cliff-edge to summit.

But it was not the forsaken, uninhabited region it is now. No ax destroyed the timber, no cattle or sheep browsed the rich pastures, but myriads of human beings had here their home. Smokes from thousands of fires spiraled the landscape as far as eye could reach, both on the mainland and the islands. Cabrillo and his companions found the natives well-disposed, peaceable fisher-folk, who, though in numbers literally swarming the islands, subsisted with little exertion on the natural food supply. They had many canoes and traded with each other and

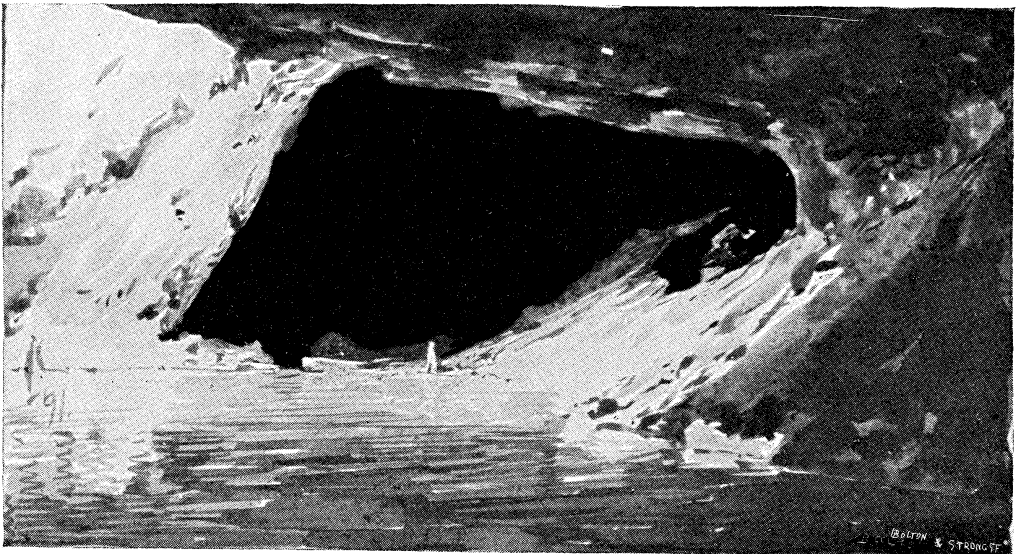


Photo by Cook.

THE GREAT CAVE, ANACAPA.

with the mainland. Then, as now, the channel teemed with many varieties of fine fish, both shoal and deep-water. Around the islands, in the vicinity of kelp beds and reefs, thousands of sea otter, seals, and sea-lions, found a breeding-ground. There were some forty species of mollusca, sea fowls and their eggs, mast, wild grains and berries, edible roots, land birds, wild fruits, and sea kale, to vary the bill of fare. The larger islands are well watered

fain to hasten back to his Bueno Porto island shelter, but died soon after, and was buried.

The spot where his bones found final "rest and peace" is by some authorities said to be on the island of La Posesion,—now San Miguel,—near Cuyler's Harbor; though centuries and the drifting sands have obliterated all traces of his tomb. There is also a more plausible legend that he was buried in one of the beautiful caves on Santa



Photo by Cook.

CAMP AT LADY HARBOR, SANTA CRUZ ISLAND.

and the temperature that of the Eastern Levant.

Here the happy explorers spent the winter, diversifying their time by frequent forays to the mainland,—which they thought was another island,—and by an extended expedition to the northland. But Cabrillo in climbing the hills on Santa Rosa Island had broken his arm early in the winter. On the northern coasts exposure to the weather and bad surgery brought on a fatal illness. The bold navigator was

Cruz Island, which he had named San Salvador, after his flagship. Santa Cruz was his favorite island.

After Cabrillo's death his *Piloto Mayor*, a Levantine named Ferrelo, took command, and lingered long about the Channel Islands. He kept a voluminous diary, and so did some of his men, verified copies of which are filed in the mission library at Santa Barbara; the originals being among the Spanish archives in Spain.

According to them, and to the rec-

ords of later explorers, also of the mission padres, there then was a denser population on the islands than on any other part of the Pacific Coast. These aborigines were greatly superior to other California Indians in physique and intelligence, and are conjectured to have been a branch of the ancient Toltecs. A collection of skulls, exhumed from various burial mounds on the islands, was sent from here eight years ago to the Smithsonian Institute. These skulls have excited much scientific discussion and show marked superiority in moral and intellectual development to the land tribes of Indians. This would suggest that our island predecessors might have evolved into a superior people had necessity, mothering invention, incited to exertion.

For untold ages life must have been, with them, an idyllic affair. They were a simple and industrious race, living on what the soil and sea gave them. They wove cloth and baskets, fashioning, sometimes with tasteful ornamentation, their weapons, household utensils, and personal adornments. About thirty tons of curiously interesting relics have been taken from their burial mounds and rancherias.

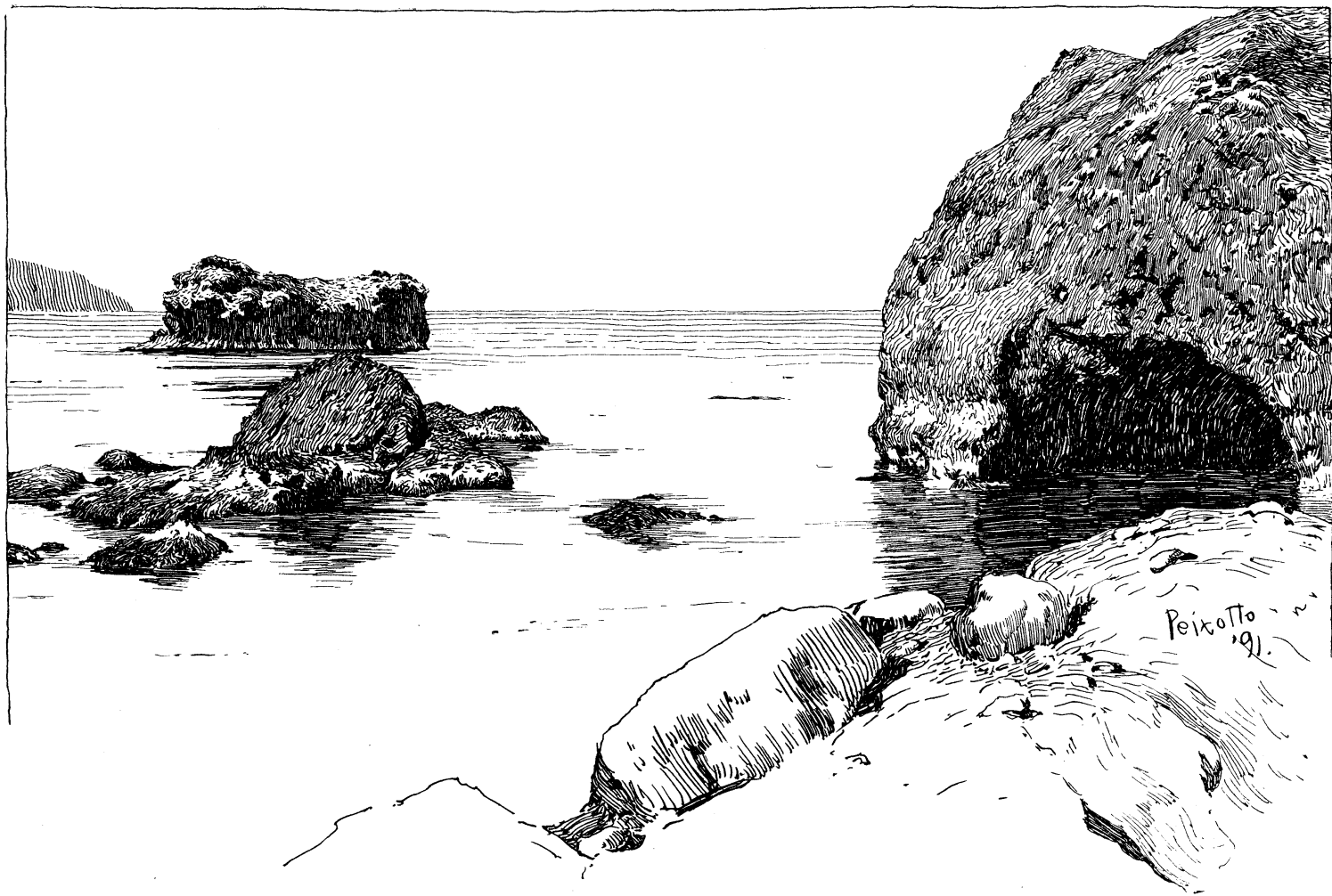
Most of these curios are now at the Smithsonian Institute, some remain in Santa Barbara, and Dr. L. G. Yates of that city has written and illustrated a number of extremely interesting papers on the subject for our State Mining Bureau. The relics consist of beadwork, shellwork in infinite variety of devices, *ollas* or water-jars of fine steatite, cooking pots, baskets, warclubs of agate, whalebone, and sandstone, crumbling fabrics of woven grass-cloths, feather robes, money, arrow-heads, spears, drills, charms, knives, whistles, cranes, mortars, stone disks, balls of war paint, bone swords, and so forth.

But as not one of this ancient race is left, their story will soon be merely legendary. Their extinction began with the raids of Alaskan and Aleut pirates,

who shortly after Cabrillo's time made a plunder-ground of these happy islands. With superior weapons and Tartar cruelty, these marauders would attack an island, kill every male they could find, and carry off all the booty they could crowd into their boats. A terrible drought is supposed to have killed off nearly all the remaining inhabitants, one rainless year. A generation has passed since the last remnants of this unique and mysterious people died, and it is not certainly known even to which of the great human families they belonged. Now a few sheepherders and solitary fishermen alone frequent the waters and shores once so populous. Seal hunters are busy there at some seasons, and an occasional excursion is made by a steamer-load of sightseers, who are taken to the most uninteresting points on the islands, allowed to look around for an hour or so, and brought back the same day.

South California credits her equable coast climate largely to the presence of these islands, while their picturesque beauty adds a distinct feature to her catalogue of scenic attractions. There is an alluring yet inaccessible air about these far-away mountains in the sea. They fascinate, yet wave the beholder back. The feeling grows the longer one lives in sight of them, and increases after having visited them. Looking across at their dimly luminous outlines from a lounging place on the beach, or better yet, from a high perch on the hills, the longing for a closer view of those dreamland mountains stirs all the rover in one's makeup.

On clear days, or days when, as often happens, mirage is in the air, the islands of San Miguel, Santa Rosa, Santa Cruz, and Anacapa, bound the greater limit of the southern ocean horizon looking from Santa Barbara. A graceful chain of amethyst or violet-hued peaks, they seem to float on the very rim of the water line, changing color-tone with each step of the sun, and taking on new



Drawn from Photo by Cook.

ENTRANCE TO TRIPLE CAVE, SANTA CRUZ ISLAND.

phases of expression as their shadows deepen or melt away. Often, under certain atmospheric alchemy, they appear linked together, overlapping like a continuous chain of mountains suspended in air, with only a ribbon of rosy mist for visible foundation.

Sometimes they indulge in a *dansa diablo*, as the Spanish fishermen here call it. That usually occurs between two rains in autumn, when the air, clear as a lens, is braided into currents of varying density. This mirage is an

beach. For nearly an hour the illusion lasted, every eye being held by the fantastic transformation apparently going on thirty miles away. The island peaks lengthened to sky-steeple, detached from their bases and sailed upward to disappear and make room for others thousands of feet high. Gigantic cupolas formed, to break like bubbles of lapis-lazuli. Hueneme cliffs, fifty miles away, lifted high on the distorted air-mirror and threw out a fairy spanwork of piers and bridges to clasp with the islands,

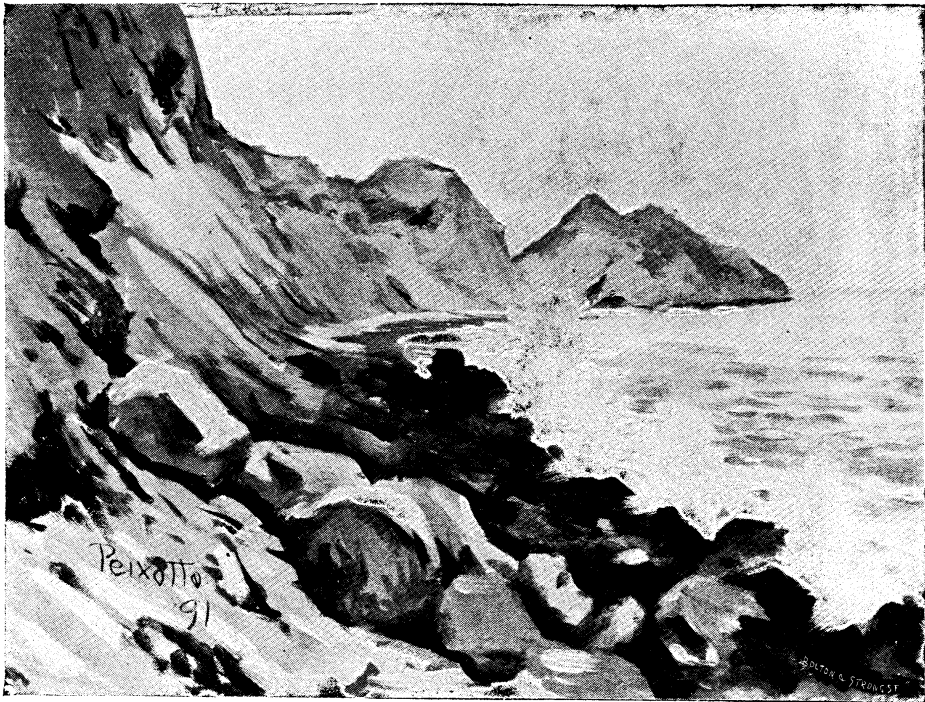


Photo by Cook.

SANTA ROSA ISLAND.

omen of ill luck to the superstitious boatman, who will rarely consent to speak of it, and who gives the Anacapa, or Demon Island as the Indians call it, a wide berth for weeks thereafter. Local tradition has it that only Spanish sailors are safe from the spells of these demons, as a good priest of Spain first blessed the Anacapa, consecrating it for his countrymen.

October 31, 1890, a very remarkable mirage was witnessed by hundreds of persons from the Santa Barbara

and spin a sort of reel around the channel, now a lake with no outlet.

The Anacapa first became a balloon, then a dragon, as became the Island of Demons; next a turreted fortress; then a medusa, and lastly a devil-fish, with antennæ writhing, and crouching like a great sea tarantula for a spring.

"No, I go not for rock cod to the islands this two or three weeks. Not till rain fall on Anacapa."

It was the Italian fisher-king of the channel who answered thus the next

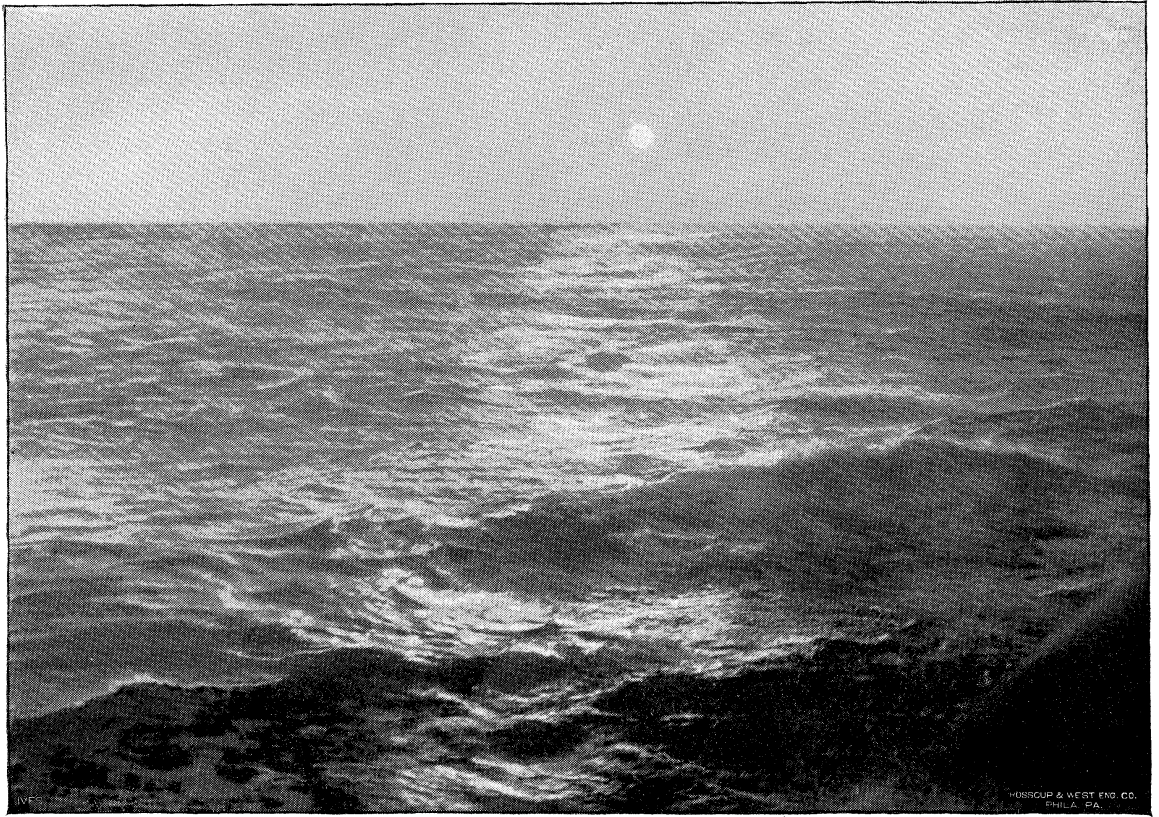


Photo by Cook.

THE ROAD TO THE ISLANDS.

day after the mirage. He would say no more, but shut himself in his vine-walled piazza for a month's net-mending.

During the mirage a spectral craft rose and melted away many times, always absorbed in the Anacapa. Finally it approached the pier, gliding straight in from the toils of the *dansa*. It was the Undine, a safe, strong little boat propelled by a tiny steam motor. Its single, sailless mast had hardly evened with the wharf when an old sailor shouted:—

“You will not be going to sea again soon?”

“Yes, to Anacapa in a day or two.”

The Undine went as usual with Joe Lord,—an old experienced sailor,—an engineer, and a Spanish boy. It never came back. Search found the Spanish boy half starved on an island reef. The Undine had capsized without known

cause off the coast of Anacapa. The white sailors were drowned, and—an unprecedented thing in these waters—their bodies were never recovered. The Undine can be seen at the bottom of the channel just this side of the Island of Demons.

This strange island repays the visitor for a few days' cruise around its unutterably desolate shores, and despite the Undine's fate a pleasure voyage was later successfully made. Three islands,—or one, with two wave-gnawed cuts through it,—Anacapa is a narrow rock nearly seven miles long. The western part is one thousand feet high; the middle and eastern three hundred and four hundred feet. The nearer it is approached the more forbidding it looks. It is solid, volcanic rock, with only one landing place, a little sand spit. All other approaches are cut off by abrupt and ghastly declivities of

rock that have been carved by the weather into repellent shapes. Through a slight fog, which nearly always blurs this island, the coast seems corniced with grimacing faces of skulls, hideous gargoyles that make one shiver. No ferns nor flowers could we find, only on the highest part a large upland or fell is covered with a queer succulent carpet of moss, on which a flock of seventy-five fat sheep were feeding. The present lessee, Captain Elliott, has now a small acreage planted to grains, fruits and alfalfa, which thrive well.

There is no water, but fog and dew are absorbed by the herbage. Sheep brought from Anacapa do not know the taste of clear water, and have been known to die of thirst beside a running stream.

Off the south shore are enormous kelp fields, the breeding place of sea otter, black seals, and the leopard or spotted seal. A wreck—the mail steamship Winfield Scott—happened near

this island about thirty years ago, and since that time Anacapa has swarmed with rats and mice, presumably from the ship. There was not a human being on the island when we visited it, and only a makeshift of a dwelling for occasional use by the proprietor.

Passing many outlying rocks and reef islands, we sailed into the Cathedral Cave. An arched roof one hundred feet high sloped down to a floor of four hundred by one hundred and fifty feet at the bottom. This floor was white sand, rimming a bay of clear water, through which marine plants, shells, and darting fishes, could be clearly seen at the pebbly bottom. Another spacious cave, high above tide water, is a veritable mine of aboriginal relics. A clear fountain of good water—the only spring on the island—gushes from a cleft in the rock into several artificial rock basins. For several feet in depth this cave is floored with all sorts of bones, shells, and other debris of an

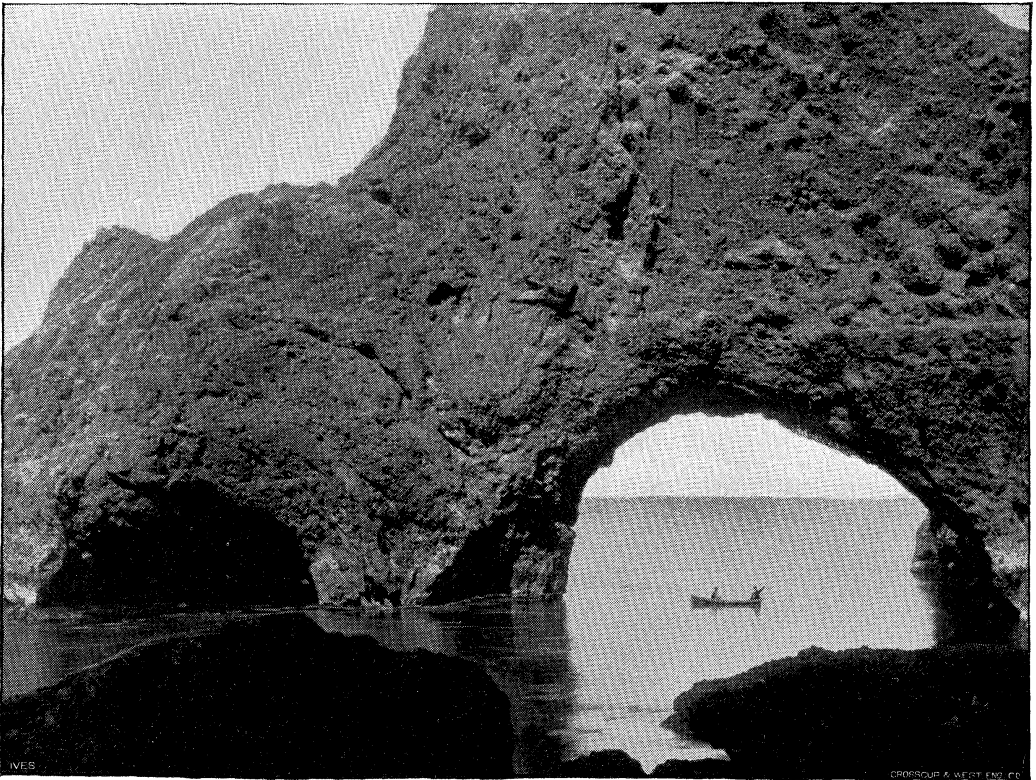


Photo by Cook.

A NATURAL BRIDGE.

Indian rancheria. Still another cave, or series of caves, reaches far into the mountain, and is inaccessible at high water. The Natural Bridge is only one of countless basaltic freaks wrought by the four elements. Gull Rock, one and one half miles from shore, is a fortress-like column, accessible only to water-fowl, seals, and expert climbers. I found the top a vast guano deposit.

A very remarkable peculiarity of the Channel Islands is their parallelism with the coast, each having its longest axis in line with the trend of the nearest strip of mainland. The four principal ones, Anacapa, Santa Cruz, Santa Rosa, and San Miguel, lie in order as mentioned from east to west, and upon the map appear strung like beads on the 34th parallel of latitude. To the south-east of these are the minor groups of San Nicolas, San Clemente, Santa Barbara, and Santa Catalina, with numerous outlying rocks, unnamed islands, and detached reefs, forming altogether quite an archipelago. All but the four Channel Islands proper parallel the main land of Los Angeles and San Diego. Of volcanic origin, they are all undoubtedly the crests of submerged mountain ranges, corresponding in direction with the shore system. But between the two ranges stretches an ocean valley nearly two hundred miles long, the smoothest natural roadstead of salt water in the world, navigators aver. On each side of it mountain walls temper or divert rough winds, the islands forming a magnificent breakwater against heavy tides.

My first visit to Santa Cruz, the second channel island going west, was in the month of April, the beauty-time of the year. Our party of nine had persuaded (not easily) Larco, the fisher-in-chief, to take take us in his best sloop, the *Genova*, with his head boatman Pasquale as crew. The sloop, lateen sail rigged, was clean and trim, with a snug hold, in which we stowed what we called necessities. There were plenty of pro-

visions, a small tent for two of our party, who were semi-invalids, guns, fishing tackle, knapsacks, a guitar, camera, artists' outfits, flower-presses, about sixty fathoms of fishing nets, and a lot of books. The last we might have omitted.

In our party were two amateur artists, three newspaper reporters, the landscape painter, Mr. H. C. Ford, and his wife, and Mr. E. P. Roe and sister, son and daughter of the novelist. Our trip was a succession of surprises and adventures hardly to be met with in an ordinary lifetime on shore.

Midway of the channel, with Santa Cruz looming high before us, a green silhouette against a tumbled mass of white cumuli, we got becalmed. The water was smooth as glass, the sun too hot and glistening for comfort. Sunshades and siestas were in order while the limp sails waited for the breeze. Larco said the tumbled clouds must bring in an hour so. Suddenly a strange spouting aroused us and a big baby whale rose a quarter of a mile away; his mother immediately appeared also. We were greatly excited over this novel sight and talked it over, wishing they had been nearer for a better view.

"They were close enough," said Pasquale; "Larco here lost his best schooner off the Farallones by a whale rising under it. A boat would splinter like kindling wood—" a chorus of exclamations finished the sentence, for a huge mound had parted the water not twenty yards from us. Another joined it. Two monstrous bulks arose like dripping islands of bronze just ahead of the boat.

"There is a big fellow on our right!" yelled some one.

"And two astern!"

The whales were all around us, only a few yards or rods away, and our boat rocked with the swell their bodies made. Full grown specimens of the California species, they looked fairly mountainous to our land-lubber gaze. Our sloop seemed like a cockle-shell convoyed by leviathans. Either of those seven mon-

sters could have sent us all to eternity with one flip of his tail.

But whales are as stupidly good-natured as cows when let alone. We let them alone, and rowing lustily away, over the very spot where one had sunk after spouting, we saw them no more.

After this the sight of shark fins was tame, and we hardly spoke when passing through a fleet of hundreds of fairy sails of the Portuguese-men-of-war, spreading their gossamer wings an oar's length away.

Seabirds rested on our mast, and strange landbirds came out to meet us, as still rowing, we made slow time. Suddenly a breeze shivered the channel into ripples, then ridges, and in five minutes whitecaps were signaling each other from leaping towers of foam all around us. It is a trick of the island waters to change thus quickly, but our sailors laughed merrily at the gale.

"No more rowing," Larco said. "Our horses have come."

The wind and sea grew rougher as we neared the island, and showers of spray dashed over us with each bound of our flying sloop. Santa Cruz looked fully its twenty-four hundred feet of altitude, and the afternoon sun brought out every line and feature distinctly. From its upper battlements of green a succession of broken hills inclined to the land's edge. The bewitchment of April had found even these remote alley-ways of spring and her vivid coloring brought out the softer charms of the landscape in rare contrast to their rugged settings. Parting the broad mesas, all aglow with poppies and dandelions, here and there a blackened ridge cropped out like a volcanic monogram. Along the high sea wall, or verging on ravines, these basaltic obtrusions became precipices, fringed now by occasional drapings of cliff mosses and the island clematis.

Santa Cruz is about twenty-two and a half miles long by five and a half in average breadth, with a superficial area of about eighty square miles. The north-

eastern shore line is mostly an irregular rampart of black basalt, with sheer descent in many places of from fifty to two hundred feet. A few narrow beaches mark the debouchment of water courses from wooded cañons. Jagged promontories reach out at frequent intervals, extending far into the breakers. The waves have sawn some of these through at the base, leaving gigantic piers and bridge-spans high above the water line.

Our sloop passed under one of these, missing the arch by a mast length. Partially submerged reefs show where other promontories have succumbed to the gnawing of the tide. Along them detached columns still do battle, like stony giants or cliff goblins at bay.

Layer upon layer of shells overcrust every atom of rock surface, giving it a scaly, etched effect. The water plays wild pranks over the notched walls. Leaping sometimes forty feet high with each movement of the tide, little serpents of foam burrow and honeycomb the cliffs and narrow promontories into the queerest shapes. They make windows through which to fling silver shuttles of spray; they bore hidden galleries where the surf dashes in at one extremity to come out at its remoter opening and fall in a powdery fretwork of mist. Nothing stranger could be imagined than these mysterious cascades bursting at regular intervals from a cliff cornice, or from a mouthlike cavity in the crest of a reef column.

From Lady Harbor for miles westward this grotesquerie of basalt and shellwork marks every foot of the coast line. Arches and caves alternate with freakish projections. The coast is like a fortification in ruins, laid by that sapper and miner, the tide, in the thousands of centuries since the volcano upreared these sea islands.

Rounding a wicked-looking reef, our boat plunged toward a narrow gate in the sea wall, and entering between two jawlike projections, we glided at once from the gale and rough sea into an

absolutely smooth harbor. It was calm as an artificial pond, and so clear that before shoal water was reached we could see the shelly bottom. A wide strip of pebbly beach was before us, margining a little cone-shaped valley some three hundred by eighty yards in area, with a small stream running through it. This apexed at the mouth of a tree-shaded cañon and was one of the prettiest spots imaginable, at once graceful and rugged, with steep, flowery bluffs on one side and a high precipice on the other.

Oak, willow, and holly, curtained the upper end of the glen; and instantly exploring this retreat we found pools of clear mountain water at the confluence of two ravines. The air was musical with the sound of cascades; each ravine, with its steep incline from highlands and over boulders, was a succession of fern beds, rushes, and lush water plants, with only the frequent flash of waterfalls to show that there was a stream.

This camping spot was our headquarters for a week. There was plenty of driftwood for fires. Abalones and fish formed the staple of our diet. Wild pigs and gawking sheep, which had no sense of discretion about running away, fed placidly within bullet range, but we molested them not. After a few days of cruising about the island, sleeping under the tent of the sky, and living on campers' fare, we began to dread a return to civilization. This was an ideal gipsying, the experience of a lifetime.

Each night and morning the nets were drawn in, bringing up marvelous catches of fish, little and big, barracouda, bass, rockcod, bonito, halibut, pompanoes, redfish, flounders, and several varieties found only in these waters. Once a seal, drowned in the net, was hauled in. Several flesh-eating sharks and a devilfish also varied the catch. At night the mackerel nets were cast, always pulling in

heavy. There was no more high wind, and our sloop fearlessly made the roughest headlands.

The island was all abloom, the air summery. We landed at hundreds of points, scaling the rocky ladders of the cliffs to the downs above. Thousands of sheep were feeding on the uplands, but not a living soul could be seen shepherding them. I have since learned that there were seventy thousand sheep on the island at that time. Now there are about sixty thousand. It is a veritable paradise for sheep. No fences to restrain, no dogs to harry, no dust to blacken the snowy fleece. They were the first clean looking flocks I had seen in California.

Flowers and grass brimmed even to the precipice's edge, and with the pale green of the wild oats, filled all the interspaces between granite ridge and cañon. Dotted everywhere were woodland thickets, amber and olive with the shimmer of new-born leaves. Our botanists filled their portfolios, though only 203 specimens of plants were found. But Professor Greene, who did the Island flora very thoroughly the same season, found and enumerated 341 species, according to his article in the Bulletin of the Academy of Sciences on collection of "Classified Ferns and Plants of Santa Cruz Island." Twenty-eight of these were peculiar to this island alone. Seventeen varieties of ferns are found here.

Our geologists also were busy with notebook and hammer, and found great variety of specimens. The whole island is of volcanic formation, the eastern portion abounding in trachyte and trachdolorite, covered in certain sections with portions of the tertiary period. There are veins of chalcedony, numerous beds of flint, and in a cut of the cañada we found submarine rocks under volcanic. There are extensive chalk deposits, pudding-stones, sandstone, with here and there a conglomerate of volcanic rock, metamorphic schists,

steatite, and the varied debris of ages of sedimentary formations.

At Prisoners' Harbor is a substantial wharf, and the only houses to be seen on a circumnavigation of the island. Here the schooners belonging to the Santa Cruz Island Company load and unload, finding good harborage the year round. The Company has begun putting the soil in this vicinity to a better use than mere pasturage. Orchards planted many years ago were found to do excellently with all sorts of fruits raised on the mainland, but experiment with wine grapes has persuaded Mr. Justinian Caire that this island is suited to viticulture. Quite a large area is now in bearing vines, and a superb wine is the result. At times from fifty to one hundred men are employed in this business. Expert wine-makers from south France have supervision, and they promise to astonish the world one day with the product of this vineyard, rooted in a volcano bed and ripened by warm salt winds in an isle of the sundown. From accessible stone quarries near at hand has been taken all the material for wine-cellar, press, and store-rooms. Mr. Caire is principal owner, and overseer of all the affairs of Santa Cruz, and may well be optimistic in his views of the possible future of his beautiful little sea-kingdom.

My article would not be complete without a history of Prisoners' Harbor, formerly kept by the Mexican government as a penal settlement. To this Botany Bay were sent some score or so of cutthroats, banditti, and the like, with provisions, live stock, seeds for planting, and so forth. These worthies did not appreciate the beauties of their place of exile. Worse than Calibans, they planned to leave immediately, after eating up everything, including seeds and live stock. Constructing a rude raft of tree-trunks, they covered it with hides from their slain cattle, and made it water-tight with a smearing of asphal-

tum found all along shore. On this craft they crossed the Channel to Santa Barbara, and forced a dubious welcome from the good mission padres, who had infinite trouble with their unbidden guests.

Castillero, the discoverer of quicksilver at Almaden, next came into possession by a Mexican grant. He sold to two firms, Barron, Forbes, & Company, and Jecker, Torre, & Company. The new owners in 1852 placed two hundred sheep on the island, finding it well watered and timbered. These have multiplied on their unshepherded ranges, bringing enormous incomes to their owners in both wool and mutton. Dr. J. B. Shaw was superintendent of the island for some years, and added the breeding of fine cattle to the sheep industry.

In years of drought, or when the island becomes overstocked, a *matanza*, or huge slaughter-house, is put in order and the sheep—sometimes over twenty thousand—are killed for their hides, tallow, and glue. 12,000 sheep were *matanzaed* in 1875. 25,000 were slaughtered in 1877.

But the greater part of the island coast is wild and lonely in the extreme. In all my sailing around and about it I never saw a human figure except at Prisoners' Harbor. All the better for the artist and lover of wild nature.

During our stay there we were up at dawn every morning. O, that I could describe those early mornings, when out on the warm, dark spread of waters we waited for the paling of the morning star, or watched the moon set in the further occident over the thousand-league waste of the Pacific!

On these expeditions we hardly spoke. Often our artists, professionals though they were, sat in a sort of daze, watching the lights and streamers and prismatic tones that each sunrise and sunset hung, a glorified aurora borealis, over the universe, with the Channel for its mirror. Each day brought a new rev-

elation of beauty, the water changing like an artist's palette with rapid laying on and blending of resplendent colors.

Once a warm, semi-opaque mist wrapped us as we rowed around ghostly headlands. Through it we could dimly perceive the outline of cave or arch with brilliant vines and phlox overhanging them. Once, as the sun arose, we came upon that rare spectacle, a fog rainbow. Over a gruesome amphitheater of chasms it hung, and through it pale apparitions, the phantoms of the surf, could be seen climbing and melting on the breast of the abyss. Adding to the weird sensation came awful moanings and wails from somewhere beyond.

Larco, with the dramatic instinct of your true Latin sailor, had chosen this time to usher us into the famous lair of the sea-lions. As we passed under a natural arch, which looked like Dore's gateway to Hades, the moans and roarings grew louder. Under another arch, which can only be made at low tide, we came upon a scene never to be pictured nor forgotten. A semicircle of beetling precipices walled in a black bay full of high rocky islets. These were hidden from sight by myriads of sea-lions. The tawny creatures looked like pyramids of enormous snails. For five minutes we watched them before a black-maned old fellow on the central boulder saw us, and roared with comical dismay. One or two harmless pistol shots sent the whole leonine convention bellowing and tumbling into the water. But their funny, black mustached faces kept popping up all around us, and glad were all parties when we discreetly backed out of their den.

The Triple or Valdez Cave, about three miles west of Lady Harbor, is one of the most interesting freaks of this strange region. We chose a bright, rather sultry day to visit it, when there was almost no force to the breakers, as most of our journey lay among shore reefs and islands. Under a shelving bluff—a rib of the mountain's backbone broken

short off at the sea wall—is a great arch, as round and symmetrical as if hewn by measurement. It roofs a cave whose spacious recesses and snowy carpet of sand invite the stranger to enter. No wind nor draft intrudes, but a delicious coolness tempered the noontime heat. Rimming the entrance an almost waveless tide came with soft laps and murmurs. Curious shells lay about, while from crevices in roof and walls, and forming a lintel over the keystone of the arch, delicate lichens, mosses, and rock-creepers, twined and nestled or swung in graceful pendulums of green, marking the standstill of time in this majestic sea temple. We renamed it Merlin's Palace. At right and left two minor arches lead out, each with its trailing portière of vine festoons. The right hand arch opens on a beautiful cove of white sand at foot of a series of lawny terraces leading to the downs above. Here we found many treasures of shells, flowers, ferns, and geological specimens. We named it Eden Cove.

The left arch was a surprise of a different nature. It was filled with the noise of churning breakers, and was promptly named the Devil's Boudoir. No sunshine entered; the place was a cul-de-sac of shelly reefs worn into a thousand frightful and sinister figures by the water, which rushing in through a straightened channel became a caldron of foam.

We climbed out on the shelly bridges and found tons of abalones. Some of these were as large as a shade-hat and they looked very odd, each with its monovalve up like a hood-trap, drinking in the showers of spray. Larco cautioned us to beware of touching them except with a sharp knife, as each has its *cardo* anchored in the solid rock and shutting down on a hand would hold the strongest man prisoner.

Last September a party of us camped by this Triple Cave, finding it as warm and dry as a house. The surf line deepens gradually from wading

depth near the entrance, and forms a beautiful aquarium. Through several fathoms of the golden-green water the bottom is clearly visible. Many of these transparent shoals we found full of queer crawling things. Swirls of sea grass and kelp make a submarine thicket, through which brilliant fishes, crabs, anemones, starfish, and the like, are at home with the coral and sea palms; sea ferns and an infinite variety of algæ abound, while shells and pebbles line the bottom.

The largest cave, called Painted Cave, on Santa Cruz Island is near the northwestern curve, and was lately discovered. Last month Captain Brown-sill of the sloop *Big Loafer*, guided a small party of us to explore this immense cavern. We rowed in, in a small skiff, through a succession of arches resembling those of a gothic cathedral. When about fifteen hundred feet from the entrance the cave branches off to right and left. From lack of proper torches, in the utter darkness we could not fully explore to the ends. The entire visible interior is brilliant with natural frescoes in color, made by mineral waters oozing through the porous rock. There was no beach, and the inner cave is closed at high tide. It is a sea lions' den.

At the Painted Cave an amber glow seemed to come from the deeper water, probably the effect of reflected sunbeams. This glow formed a halo of little yellow points around every submerged object, and with each pulse of the tide there was a curious undulating movement, as though some hand from the further depths was rocking this tiny cove cradle.

There is another sea-lions' den near the spot. It is a hole or natural tunnel leading to unknown caves up under the mountain. The sailors say that it must be miles long, and contain high and dry chambers, for when full tide covers the entrance and shuts off the hideous roarings and bellowings always

heard at other times, the sea-lions do not come out, as they must from a cave filled with water. Thousands of them breed there.

There are no snakes or poisonous reptiles on the islands; no tarantulas, scorpions, frogs, or centipedes,—a small red fox and the skunk, are, I believe, the only wild animals.

Santa Rosa is slightly smaller than Santa Cruz and resembles it in its general soil, products, and adaptability to cultivation. It is very irregular, nearly quadrilateral, with a precipitous broken coast line. It is not so high as Santa Cruz, its loftiest peak being only about six hundred feet. Its greatest length is $16\frac{1}{2}$ miles. The average length is $9\frac{3}{4}$ miles; average width about $7\frac{1}{2}$ miles. Its area is about 74 square miles. There are a few good landings, but no bays nor harbors. It is now in possession of A. P. More, and is pasturage for about sixty thousand sheep; no other use being made of it. It is a very valuable property and from good authority I learn that the owner last year refused \$750,000 for it, his price being a million. A few herders remain on the island most of the year, and during the semi-annual shearing times a large force of Spanish shearers is employed. In flora and fauna, Indian relics and geological features, this island closely resembles Santa Cruz. The coast and inland rocks are worn by the weather into caves and fissures. Many of these seem to have served as dwellings for the aborigines.

One hundred and fifty varieties of mollusca from this island alone have been named, of which nearly thirty were used by the Indians as food. There is a wharf at Five-mile Bight. Few visitors are allowed to land.

San Miguel, the western of the Channel Islands, is $7\frac{1}{3}$ by $2\frac{1}{2}$ miles in dimensions. It belongs to San Luis Obispo County, and like the others, is devoted to sheep-raising. It is the least interesting of the four.

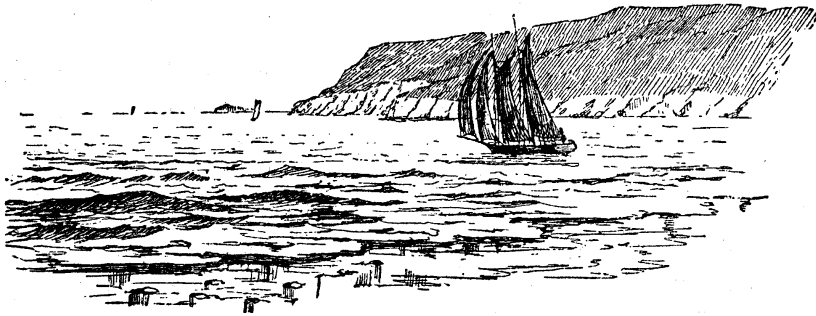
Of the minor islands San Nicolas is famous as the home for years of a solitary woman, who lived on fish, roots, and seal-blubber and dressed in skins and feather robes. She was finally rescued and brought to Santa Barbara, where she died. No clue was ever found to her nationality or language. She was brown-skinned, with intelligent features, small hands and feet, and she was wonderfully refined for an Indian or Malaysian.

Far-off Catalina furnishes us with shiploads of glistening pebbles, of which

I am so fortunate as to possess a garden walk. On this island in 1603 Viscaíño found a bronze-haired race of fishermen and traders, who lived in shell-thatched houses and sacrificed birds to an idol in a temple. Each island has its story or legend.

Tales of buried treasure haunt all these whilom retreats of the old buccaneers. Many have searched especially for Cabrillo's treasure, supposed to be hidden somewhere on Santa Cruz. But if any such has ever been found the finder kept his secret well.

Martinette Kinsell.



CONTRAST.

HERE, through wide windows, traceried o'er and o'er
With fretted frost-work, — carven spire and dome,
Gray rocks encrusted with a silver foam,
Pale flowers that scatter fragrance nevermore,
And bud and leaf and spray in countless store, —
O'er desolate wastes of snow my glance doth roam
To ice-clad hills, the haunt of elf and gnome,
Bedecked like palaces of fairy-lore.

For you the summer's myriad raptures wait
Where Nature's Eden unpolluted lies; —
The song of happy birds, the hum of bees,
The salt winds blown across the crested seas, —
And earth our dream of heaven typifies
In sunset glories of the Golden Gate!

Sarah Dyer Hobart.